

Building Apps for ChatGPT

Strategy, Market Opportunity, and Product Design Principles

1. Purpose of This Document

This document serves as **strategic background** for multiple product development initiatives targeting **ChatGPT apps**.

It consolidates insights about:

- The current state of the ChatGPT app platform
- How ChatGPT apps fundamentally differ from traditional apps
- OpenAI's implicit and explicit guidance on what constitutes a *good* vs *bad* app
- Why **discoverability via intent** is the core growth lever
- Which kinds of problems are well-suited (and poorly suited) to the ChatGPT app model
- How these dynamics translate into **real business opportunity**

The goal is to ensure that *every product idea* is evaluated against the **actual mechanics of the platform**, not surface analogies to mobile or web apps.

2. Market Opportunity Right Now

2.1 Why This Is a Platform Shift (Not Just a Feature)

ChatGPT is transitioning from:

"a conversational interface"
to
a general-purpose execution environment

Key characteristics:

- Hundreds of millions of active users already present
- No app-install friction
- Discovery driven by *user intent*, not marketing
- Apps invoked at the exact moment of need

This resembles:

- The launch of the iOS App Store
- The rise of Google Search as a distribution channel

...but with **orders of magnitude more built-in demand** on day one.

2.2 Timing Advantage

Current conditions:

- Third-party apps are accepted and listed
- Competition inside categories is extremely low
- Discovery mechanics are still forming
- Monetization is emerging but not yet saturated

This creates a **land-grab window** where:

- Early, high-quality apps can become defaults
 - Brand recognition matters less than execution quality
 - Structural advantages compound quickly
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3. What a ChatGPT App Actually Is

3.1 The Correct Mental Model

A ChatGPT app is **not**:

- A mobile app inside ChatGPT
- A mini-website embedded in chat
- A destination the user navigates to

A ChatGPT app **is**:

A specialized capability that ChatGPT can invoke to better fulfill user intent.

ChatGPT:

- Owns the user relationship
- Controls the conversation
- Decides *when* and *whether* to call an app

Apps:

- Provide execution, data, or structured flows
 - Enhance ChatGPT's ability to act
 - Are ideally invisible unless needed
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3.2 "Invisible Upgrade" Model

The strongest apps feel like:

"ChatGPT suddenly got better at this."

Users should feel:

- continuity, not switching
 - help, not sales
 - outcomes, not interfaces
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4. Discovery: The Central Mechanism

4.1 Discovery Is Intent-Based, Not Store-Based

Users do not primarily:

- browse app listings
- compare features
- install apps intentionally

Instead:

1. User expresses an intent in natural language
2. ChatGPT recognizes the intent
3. ChatGPT routes execution to the best available tool
4. The app is invoked as part of the response

Discovery is a side effect of usefulness.

4.2 What Gets an App Discovered

Apps are favored when they:

- Solve a clearly identifiable intent
- Do so better than ChatGPT alone
- Are reliable, fast, and safe
- Reduce friction or cognitive load
- Produce clear outcomes

You do **not** compete on:

- branding
- screenshots
- marketing copy

You compete on:

- execution quality
 - intent match
 - user satisfaction signals
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5. What Makes a Problem a Good Fit for ChatGPT Apps

5.1 High-Fit Problem Characteristics

Strong candidates typically have:

- **Explicit user language**
("help me", "find", "book", "calm me", "organize")
- **Repeatability**
Daily or frequent recurrence

- **Actionability**
Something must *happen*, not just be discussed
 - **Structure potential**
A system, protocol, or workflow improves outcomes
 - **External dependency**
Data, inventory, accounts, or execution beyond ChatGPT
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5.2 Poor-Fit Problem Characteristics

Weak candidates include:

- Purely passive content consumption
 - Tasks requiring constant background execution
 - Problems needing push notifications to work
 - Vague, exploratory use cases without outcomes
 - Apps that duplicate generic ChatGPT behavior
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6. OpenAI's Implicit Product Philosophy

While OpenAI publishes limited explicit rules, patterns are clear.

6.1 What OpenAI Wants

OpenAI favors apps that:

- Increase user trust in ChatGPT
- Reduce hallucination risk
- Provide reliable execution
- Are safe for broad audiences
- Feel helpful, not promotional

Apps are judged on:

- user experience
 - safety
 - correctness
 - contribution to overall platform value
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6.2 What OpenAI Discourages

Apps are likely penalized or rejected if they:

- Manipulate users
- Create emotional dependency
- Masquerade as something they are not (e.g. therapy)
- Overstep safety boundaries

- Exist primarily for advertising or upselling

In sensitive domains, restraint and clarity are rewarded.

7. Monetization Reality

7.1 Current State

At present:

- No native in-chat billing
- Monetization handled externally
- Subscriptions, programs, or services linked out

This favors:

- High-value use cases
 - Subscription-friendly models
 - Long-term user relationships
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7.2 Strategic Implication

Early apps should:

- Optimize for usage and trust
- Build habit and identity
- Delay aggressive monetization
- Be ready for future native payments

Distribution now > monetization now.

8. No Notifications: A Crucial Constraint

8.1 What Does Not Exist

Currently unavailable:

- Push notifications
- Scheduled reminders
- Background app execution
- App-initiated messages

Apps are **reactive**, not proactive.

8.2 What This Means

Apps must win by:

- Being top-of-mind when the need arises

- Creating rituals users return to voluntarily
- Aligning with moments of felt need

This heavily favors:

- Intent-driven wellbeing
 - Situational assistance
 - Habitual but self-initiated use
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9. Implications for Product Strategy

9.1 Design for Routing, Not Adoption

Ask:

- "When would ChatGPT need this capability?" Not:
 - "How do we get users to install this?"
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9.2 Optimize for Trust Before Growth

Routing favors:

- reliable apps
- predictable outcomes
- conservative behavior in sensitive areas

Trust compounds.

9.3 Narrow Beats Broad

The winning pattern:

- Own a narrow, frequent intent deeply
 - Become the default executor
 - Expand only after dominance
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10. Summary Principles (Use as a Checklist)

A strong ChatGPT app:

- Solves a clear, common intent
 - Feels like a natural extension of ChatGPT
 - Produces outcomes, not conversations
 - Requires minimal explanation
 - Is safe, reliable, and restrained
 - Builds return behavior without reminders
 - Creates value that compounds over time
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Final Note

ChatGPT apps are not a new distribution channel.
They are a **new execution layer for human intent**.

Products that align with this reality will feel inevitable.
Those that don't will feel bolted on.

Use this document as a filter.
If a product idea does not clearly benefit from ChatGPT's intent-routing model, it likely belongs elsewhere.

End of document.